

FIND A THERAPIST ON A SLIDING SCALE

It's extremely messed up that treatment and preventive care for most physical ailments is covered if you have insurance, but many necessary mental health treatments are not. While needing to get mental health treatment on the cheap sucks, it's also supremely unfair that even those *with* insurance might need this bit of advice: Some therapists allow you to pay according to your income. When I lived New York, I saw someone for ninety minutes for \$80 or sixty minutes for \$40. (I always chose the sixty-minute option.)

Sometimes I could see them for nothing at all if I'd had a particularly rough week. My therapist was a psychology student working toward the hours she needed to graduate. I assumed paying less for therapy meant the care wouldn't be as good, but that's not true. You can also find psychiatrists on a sliding scale, but most friends I spoke to said they see one within their insurance network. Even your in-network providers may suddenly become out-of-network. This has happened to me a few times, requiring me to start over with another doctor, which can be stressful and make you feel vulnerable.

My current talk therapist in LA allows exemptions and discounts, though she's not on my insurance plan, because she trusts me and because I asked. There's no shame in asking if money is tight.

SEEK ADDICTION TREATMENT ONLINE

Alcoholics Anonymous and AlAnon meetings are free to attend, as are other recovery meetings. For online addiction recovery, there's a free site called In the Rooms. It's like Facebook for addicts and alcoholics and has a video chat feature for free online AA and NA (Narcotics Anonymous) meetings. The site's been a big help for my dad and his friends who can't afford rehab or medical services. It's not a replacement for more comprehensive recovery, but it helps when there's no other option.